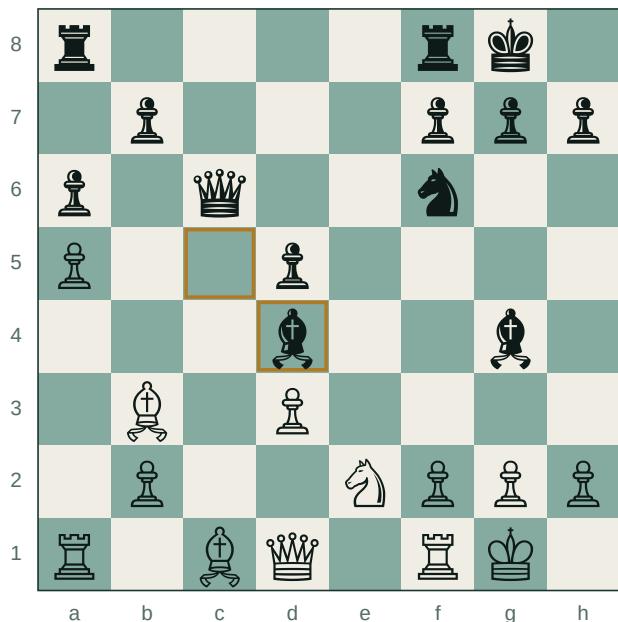


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 16

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 15...Bxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16. Nxd4 Bxd1 17. Nxc6

16.Nxd4 The knight captures the bishop on d4. The changed line means the queen on d1 attacks the bishop on g4. Recorded reply: **16...Bxd1**.

17.Nxc6 The knight captures the queen on c6.

At the end, nominal material is White 25 / Black 22 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on d4. Check for tactical protection.